over his troops in Cuba to Fidel Castro, who was himself prone to panic and eager to fight the Americans.[7]

As I examined my sources, which included recently released KGB files, for errors committed by Kennedy, Khrushchev, and their advisers and subordinates, I could not help posing the question of what prevented nuclear war from breaking out. A great deal—too much, one might say—depended on the decisions of the leaders, so different in background, political trajectory, ideological views, and managerial styles. But as I argue in this book, they had one thing in common that proved decisive—fear of nuclear war. The crisis did not develop into a shooting war because Kennedy and Khrushchev both feared nuclear weapons and dreaded the very idea of their use.

Kennedy, who wanted to strike at the Soviet missiles on Cuba, turned to a blockade once he understood that the missiles were ready to fire. Khrushchev, initially willing to prevent a possible US attack on Cuba by using nuclear missiles, ordered his ships to turn back once he learned of the blockade and brought Soviet missiles out of Cuba when nuclear-armed American strategic bombers went on high alert. The two leaders hastened to compromise on American missiles in Turkey when they realized that they were losing control on the ground and in the air, as demonstrated by the Soviet downing of an American U-2 plane over Cuba without authorization from Moscow. Later, Khrushchev removed even undetected nuclear weapons from the island to avoid causing another crisis and, potentially, war.

Kennedy, Khrushchev, and their generation of world leaders and the citizens of their countries came of age in the shadow of the atomic bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, as well as the mind-boggling destructive power demonstrated by the hydrogen bomb tests of Castle Bravo by the Americans in 1954 and the Tsar Bomba (Emperor Bomb) by the Soviets in 1961. That generation was keenly aware of the destruction that atomic and especially hydrogen bombs could wreak on their countries and humankind as a whole. Every move of the two leaders described in this book was dictated by their fear of the use of nuclear weapons. There is little doubt that today there are world leaders prepared to take a more cavalier attitude toward nuclear weapons and nuclear war than Kennedy and Khrushchev had in 1962.